

- RAG Learning

3.5 Feminism

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 3 (Political Ideas)

Feminism holds that women are systematically disadvantaged because of their sex, that this disadvantage is **socially produced rather than natural**, and that it should be ended. Its strands disagree sharply about the cause and the remedy — which is why "is feminism a single ideology?" is a standard exam question.

Optional ideology. Students study *one* of nationalism, feminism, multiculturalism, anarchism or ecologism.

AQA key thinkers for feminism: Charlotte Perkins Gilman, Simone de Beauvoir, Kate Millett, Sheila Rowbotham and bell hooks.

1. Core ideas

Sex and gender

The foundational analytical distinction.

- **Sex** — biological difference between males and females; given.
- **Gender** — the social roles, behaviours and expectations attached to those categories (masculinity, femininity); culturally constructed and varying across societies and over time.

Why it matters: it undermines the argument that women's subordinate position is natural and therefore inevitable. If the roles are constructed, they can be changed. De Beauvoir's claim that one is not born but *becomes* a woman expresses this directly.

Patriarchy

Literally "rule by the father". Feminists use it to describe a **system** of social structures, practices and beliefs through which men as a group dominate women as a group. Its significance is that it identifies women's subordination as *systemic* rather than the product of individual prejudice — located in the family, the labour market, the law, culture and sexuality.

The personal is political

Relationships within the private sphere are structured by power and are therefore properly political. Who does the housework, how childcare is distributed, and the dynamics of marriage, sexuality and reproduction are instances of a wider system of male dominance, not merely private arrangements.

Equality and difference

- **Equality feminism** — minimise the political significance of sex difference; seek identical treatment.
- **Difference feminism** — there are genuine differences that should be recognised and valued, rather than erased by a standard of equality modelled on men's lives.

Intersectionality

Race, class and gender oppression **interlock**, producing distinct experiences that cannot be understood by analysing any one axis in isolation. The position of a poor black woman is not the sum of racism, poverty and sexism but a specific condition of its own.

2. Key thinkers

Charlotte Perkins Gilman (1860–1935) — *Women and Economics* (1898)

- **Economic dependence** — women's subordination is rooted in their economic dependence on men, reinforced by confinement to the domestic sphere.
- **The "sexuo-economic relation"** — women's survival depending on attracting and retaining a male provider distorts their development and character.
- **Socialising domestic labour** — her solution: communal kitchens, laundries and childcare, freeing women to enter paid employment on equal terms.

- **Gender roles are learned**, not natural — an early statement of the sex/gender distinction.

Simone de Beauvoir (1908–1986) — *The Second Sex* (1949)

- **"One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman"** — femininity is a socially constructed identity imposed through culture, not a natural consequence of biological sex.
- **Woman as "the Other"** — man is treated as the norm and the universal human subject; woman is defined *in relation to him*, and therefore as deviation rather than as an autonomous subject.
- **Existentialist foundation** — women must transcend the passive role assigned to them and assert themselves as free subjects.

Kate Millett (1934–2017) — *Sexual Politics* (1970)

- **Relations between the sexes are political** — power relations, not private matters.
- **Patriarchy operates through culture** — through literature, art, religion and the family, which condition both sexes into accepting male dominance as natural. It is therefore reproduced through consent as much as through force.
- **The family as the chief instrument** of patriarchal socialisation.
- **A cultural revolution**, not merely legal reform, is required.

Sheila Rowbotham (b. 1943) — *Hidden from History* (1973)

- **Socialist feminism** — women's oppression is bound up with capitalism.
- **Unpaid domestic labour** reproduces the workforce at no cost to employers; women also function as a **reserve army of labour**, drawn in when needed and pushed out when not, depressing wages generally.
- **"Hidden from history"** — women's contributions have been systematically written out of historical record.
- **Against economic reductionism** — she insisted socialist analysis must address women's *specific* oppression rather than treating it as a secondary consequence of class that would dissolve automatically after a revolution.

bell hooks (1952–2021) — *Ain't I a Woman?* (1981)

- **Intersectionality** — race, class and gender oppression interlock and cannot be analysed separately.
- **Critique of mainstream feminism** — it had been dominated by white, middle-class, educated women and presented their experience as universal. Friedan's account of frustrated suburban housewives did not describe black women who had always worked outside the home from economic necessity — for whom paid employment was obligation, not liberation.
- **Feminism as a movement to end sexist oppression**, connected to anti-racist and class politics rather than separate from them.

3. Strands of feminism

	Liberal	Socialist	Radical	Postmodern / postcolonial
Cause of oppression	Legal discrimination and cultural conditioning	Capitalism, which benefits from unpaid domestic labour and a cheap reserve workforce	Patriarchy — the original and deepest form of oppression	Discourses that construct the very category "woman"; colonialism and racism as well as gender
Sphere of concern	Public sphere	Economic structures	Public <i>and</i> private — family, sexuality, culture	Language, identity, representation; women outside the West
Remedy	Equal rights, equal opportunity, changed attitudes	Economic transformation	Revolutionary transformation of personal life and culture	Deconstructing fixed categories
Thinkers	Wollstonecraft, Friedan	Rowbotham	Millett; de Beauvoir (partly)	hooks (intersectional critique)

Post-colonial feminism argues that Western feminism universalised the experience of women in the Global North and ignored how colonialism and race shape women's oppression elsewhere. It links directly to hooks' intersectional critique: there is no single female condition that one strand of feminism can speak for.

Exam Tip: Liberal feminism delivered most of the concrete legal gains of the twentieth century — suffrage, equal pay legislation, access to the professions — because it built on principles society already accepted. Its limitation is equally clear: formal legal equality has been substantially achieved in Western societies while substantive inequality persists in pay, domestic labour and representation. That gap is the strongest evidence for the structural critiques.

4. The public/private divide

A crucial dividing line. **Liberal feminism largely accepts it**, campaigning for equality in the public sphere and valuing the private sphere as a zone protected from state intrusion. **Radical feminism rejects it**, arguing the divide is itself the mechanism by which women's subordination is shielded from scrutiny.

What politicising the private achieved: it made domestic violence, marital rape, unpaid domestic labour, reproductive rights and sexual harassment into political questions requiring public remedy. Consciousness-raising groups rested on the insight that individual experiences shared across many women revealed a structural pattern.

5. Tensions within feminism

Disagreement	One side	The other
Reform or transformation	Liberal — equal rights within existing structures	Radical / socialist — the structures themselves produce the inequality
Primary cause	Socialist — capitalism; class is fundamental	Radical — patriarchy predates capitalism and persisted in socialist states

Equality or difference	Identical treatment; minimise sex difference	Recognise and value distinctively female experience
Can feminism speak for all women?	A shared female condition unites women	hooks, postmodernists — "woman" is not a single stable category
The private sphere	Liberal — a zone of freedom to protect	Radical — a site of power requiring political scrutiny

Exam Tip: The equality/difference debate is a **genuine dilemma**, not an error on either side, and it has concrete consequences. Identical treatment can ignore pregnancy and caring responsibilities; recognising difference risks reinforcing the essentialism historically used to justify exclusion. Maternity provision illustrates the resolution most policy reaches: treating women differently *precisely in order to* make equal participation possible.

6. Is feminism a single ideology?

No	Yes
The strands rest on incompatible foundations — liberal individualism, Marxist class analysis, the primacy of patriarchy	All share the core claims: women are systematically disadvantaged because of their sex; this is socially produced; it should end
They diagnose different causes and prescribe different remedies	All accept the sex/gender distinction and reject biological determinism
Intersectionality and postmodernism question whether there is a single subject "woman" at all	Solidarity can rest on a shared <i>political project</i> rather than an assumed identity of experience — arguably a firmer foundation than the false universalism it replaced

Key terms

Term	Definition
Patriarchy	A system of structures and practices through which men dominate women
Sex / gender	Biological difference / socially constructed roles and expectations
The personal is political	Private-sphere relationships are sites of power and properly political concerns
The Other	Woman defined in relation to man as the norm (de Beauvoir)
Essentialism	The view that women have fixed natural characteristics
Intersectionality	Race, class and gender oppression interlocking rather than adding up
Reserve army of labour	Women drawn into and pushed out of the workforce as capital requires
Consciousness-raising	Sharing personal experience to reveal structural patterns
Difference feminism	Recognising and valuing distinctively female experience
Cultural feminism	Emphasising the superiority or distinct value of female attributes
Separatism	Advocating women's withdrawal from relationships with men
Dual-systems theory	Treating patriarchy and capitalism as distinct but mutually reinforcing